

PART 10: SOFT SKILLS & PM LEADERSHIP

10.0 Why this chapter has the highest leverage

Two PMs with identical technical skills can have wildly different careers based on what's in this chapter. The difference between Senior PM and Director isn't usually framework knowledge; it's the ability to navigate the human dimension of the work. This chapter includes the things most PM books treat softly: actual scripts for actual conversations you'll have, including the conversations about your own career that nobody trained you for.

10.1 The leadership shift — from doing to influencing

In your first year, you ship things personally. By year three, you ship through other people. By year five, you're judged on what your team accomplishes, not what you personally produced.

The shift is hard. It requires:

- Letting go of personal control over outcomes.
- Trusting your team to execute.
- Investing time in conversations and alignment that don't show up as "output."
- Measuring yourself by team outcomes, not individual ticket count.

PMs who never make the shift plateau as senior individual contributors with high doing but limited leading. PMs who make it become product leaders.

Three indicators you're making the shift

1. **Your calendar shifts.** Less time on tasks; more on conversations, mentoring, strategy.
2. **Your team's autonomy grows.** They don't need you to make decisions in their domain.
3. **You celebrate other people's wins more than your own.**

The hardest part

You will have moments where you could do something faster yourself than coaching someone else through it. Resist. Doing it yourself wins the day; coaching wins the year. The team that learns to do things without you is the team that scales.

10.2 Influence without authority — the PM's central skill

PMs don't have hire/fire authority over engineers, designers, or anyone else. Yet they need those people to do specific things with quality and urgency. The mechanism: trust + clarity + reciprocity. Not commands.

Five foundations of influence

1. **Competence.** People follow PMs they respect. Demonstrate you understand the domain, make sound decisions, know what you're doing.
2. **Trust.** People support PMs they trust. Trust is built through reliability (do what you say), transparency (share information openly), and respect (acknowledge their expertise).
3. **Care.** People go the extra mile for PMs who care about them. Notice when an engineer is overloaded. Remember the designer's sick parent. Help when you can.
4. **Vision.** People are pulled toward PMs with clear vision. Articulate where you're going and why. Make it inspiring.
5. **Reciprocity.** Give before you ask. Help others' projects, defend their interests, share credit. Influence flows back.

The currency of influence

Different stakeholders care about different things. Frame your asks in their currency:

Stakeholder	What they care about	How to frame requests
Engineering	Technical quality, sustainability, learning	"This will reduce on-call load and let us ship faster"
Design	User outcomes, craft, voice in process	"Your input will shape what we measure"
Sales	Deals closed, quota	"This unblocks 5 deals worth \$X"
Marketing	Differentiation, story	"This gives us a clear narrative for launch"
Customer Support	Ticket volume, agent satisfaction	"This will cut tickets in [category] by 30%"
Finance	ROI, payback period, risk	"Estimated \$X impact over 12 months at \$Y cost"
Leadership	OKRs, strategic alignment	"Drives the activation OKR by 15%"

A PM who fluidly translates the same decision into different stakeholders' currencies has step-changed their influence.

Practical influence techniques

Technique 1: The "we" frame. Instead of "I think we should do X," say "What if we tried X — what's missing for that to work?" The first sets you up against them; the second invites collaboration.

Technique 2: Ask for help, not approval. "I'm struggling with this trade-off — can I get your perspective?" lowers defenses. "I've decided X — sign off?" gets compliance without engagement.

Technique 3: Make trade-offs visible. "To do X, we'd give up Y. Are you OK with that trade-off?" People respect honesty.

Technique 4: Find the smallest yes. Big change is hard to agree to. Small low-risk version: easy. "Could we test this with 5 customers first?" Then iterate.

Technique 5: Pre-wire decisions. Don't unveil major decisions in big meetings. Talk to each stakeholder 1-on-1 first. By the meeting, you've already addressed concerns; the meeting is alignment, not negotiation.

Technique 6: Use data ethically. Data should inform, not weaponize. PMs who selectively cite data to win arguments are seen through in 6 months.

Technique 7: Acknowledge tradeoffs explicitly when you disagree. "I see why you'd want X. Here's why I'm leaning toward Y, and here's what we lose by choosing Y." Acknowledging their perspective costs nothing and earns respect.

10.3 The first 90 days — building trust as a new PM

When you're new (whether new to the company or new to PM), the first 90 days disproportionately shape how you'll be perceived for years. Get this wrong and you'll spend a long time digging out.

Days 1-30: Listen more than you speak

- Meet everyone. 1:1 with engineers, designers, key cross-functional partners, top customers, support team. Aim for 30+ conversations.
- Ask "what's working" and "what's broken" in each. Take notes. Don't argue.
- Read everything. Past PRDs, user research, dashboards, OKRs, retrospectives.
- Use the product daily as a power user.
- Don't propose changes yet. You haven't earned the right.

The temptation is to "make your mark" by week 2. Resist. Most quick mark-making is regretted by month 3 when you understand context better.

Days 31-60: Pattern recognition

- Synthesize what you've heard. Top 3 user pains? Top 3 team frustrations? Top 3 strategic questions?

- Validate your synthesis. Share with manager and 2-3 trusted peers. Are you reading the situation right?
- Find a small, easy win. A low-risk improvement that helps the team — fix a broken process, ship a quick clarity-improving doc, unblock something. Demonstrates competence without disrupting.
- Begin engaging on bigger questions. But still mostly listen.

Days 61-90: Earn the right to lead

- Form a point of view. What's your read on strategy, gaps, opportunities? Write it down.
- Share your POV thoughtfully. Not as pronouncement but as contribution. "Here's how I see things; what am I missing?"
- Take ownership of a meaningful initiative. Drive it well. Communicate clearly. This becomes your visible track record.
- Build a rhythm: weekly product updates, stakeholder syncs, retros. Show up reliably.

By day 90, you should be a trusted, effective contributor who's earned the right to challenge things.

Common first-90-day mistakes

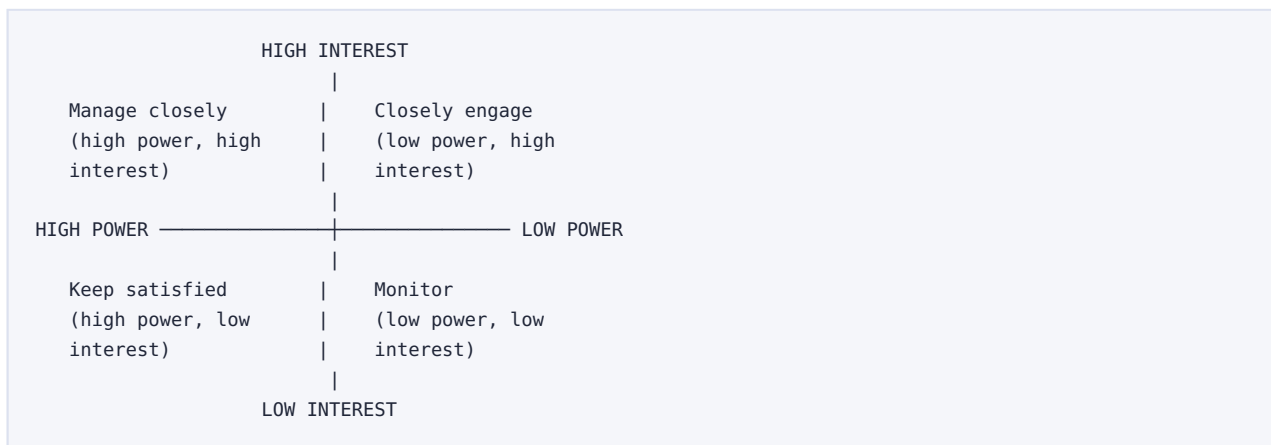
- **Lecturing.** "Best practices from my last company" makes you sound like a critic.
- **Rapid restructuring.** Changing process before understanding why current process exists.
- **Skipping 1:1s.** Trust is built in 1:1s; you can't shortcut it.
- **Overpromising.** Making early commitments you later have to break.
- **Being too quiet.** The opposite extreme — never sharing perspective also slows trust-building. Find a middle path.

10.4 Stakeholder management framework

PMs work with many stakeholders, each with different priorities. A systematic approach prevents random drift.

Step 1: Map stakeholders

For your project, list everyone whose support, input, or buy-in matters. Group by power × interest:



- **Manage closely:** CEO, VP Product, head of Eng for your area, top 3 customers. Frequent, deep engagement.
- **Closely engage:** Designers, engineers, customer success leads. Active partners.
- **Keep satisfied:** Senior leaders adjacent to your area, finance, legal. Regular updates, no surprises.
- **Monitor:** Other PMs, peers, ancillary teams. Periodic check-ins.

The most common mistake: treating all stakeholders the same way. Customize cadence and depth.

Step 2: Understand each stakeholder's goals

For each high-priority stakeholder, ask yourself:

- What are their personal incentives (career, OKRs, relationships)?
- What do they want from this product/project?
- What are they worried about?
- What does success look like for them?

If you can't answer these, you don't understand them. Have a 1:1 to find out.

Step 3: Communicate proactively

- **Manage Closely:** Weekly or bi-weekly 1:1s. Pre-wire major decisions. Share wins and risks.
- **Closely Engage:** Daily standup presence; sprint reviews; pair on hard decisions.
- **Keep Satisfied:** Monthly written updates. Surface risks early. Don't surprise them.
- **Monitor:** Quarterly catch-ups. Loop in on relevant items.

Stakeholder personality types

You'll encounter recurring stakeholder archetypes. Recognizing them helps:

- **The Skeptic:** Always questions; needs evidence. Win them with data and rigor.
- **The Champion:** Believes in you. Don't take for granted; over-communicate.

- **The Blocker:** Says no by default. Often has a real concern; ask what would change their mind.
- **The Ghost:** Disengaged. Needs a clear, narrow ask to re-engage.
- **The Expert:** Has deep knowledge. Lean on them; cite them in decisions.
- **The Politico:** Optimizes for relationships, not outcomes. Be careful — alignment may be performative. Verify.
- **The Dreamer:** Loves big ideas; weak on execution. Translate dreams into specific bets.

You won't change anyone's personality. Adapt your approach to each.

10.5 The scripts — for difficult conversations PMs actually have

This is the section the brief specifically asked for. Most PM books skip it. Here are the conversations you will have, with scripts.

These aren't scripts to memorize. They're scaffolds. Adapt to your voice. The structure is what matters.

Script 1: "I want my title changed to Product Manager"

Context: You've been doing PM work for 12+ months under a different title (Senior Analyst, BA, Senior Associate, etc.). You want recognition.

Setup: Schedule a dedicated 30-minute slot with your manager. Frame it as "career conversation." Don't ambush them in a regular 1:1.

Opening:

"Thanks for taking the time. I want to talk about my role and how I'd like it to evolve. Specifically, I'd like to discuss having my title change to Product Manager.

The reason I'm raising this: over the last 12 months, I've been doing the work of a PM — I own [list 3-5 specific products or modules], I drive ideation and prioritization, I write specs and own delivery, I'm accountable for outcomes. The work is PM work; my title isn't. I'd like to align them.

I'm not raising this to ask for a comp bump (though I'd like to discuss that separately). I'm raising it because the title affects how I'm perceived inside the company by partners I haven't worked with, how I'm perceived externally if I ever speak at a meetup or write publicly, and how I think of my own contributions.

I'd love to hear your read. Is this a conversation you can have, or does it need to go somewhere else?"

Manager response paths:

Path A: "Yes, this makes sense, let me work on it." Follow up: "Thank you. What's the timeline I should expect? Is there anything I can do to support — for example, document the scope I've been owning?"

Path B: "I agree but our company doesn't have PM titles in this band." Follow up: "I understand the constraint. Can we talk about what would need to change for that to happen? Is there a band where the PM title exists? What's the path to that band?"

This response has shifted the conversation from "title" to "leveling" — sometimes the right framing.

Path C: "I'm not sure your work is at the PM level." This is a hard response. Stay calm. Don't argue.

"I appreciate you being honest. Can you help me understand specifically? What would the gap need to look closed? I'd like to know what to invest in."

Get specifics. Then evaluate: is the gap real (you have something to learn) or political (the company doesn't promote PM titles regardless)? If real, work on it for 6 months and revisit. If political, this is information for whether you should stay.

Path D: "Why not stay as Senior Analyst — it's working for you." The "if it ain't broke" response.

"It's working for the work I do today. I'm thinking about the next 3-5 years. I want to grow into more PM ownership, more influence, more strategic scope. The title change isn't just retroactive recognition; it's setting up the next phase. Does that change the conversation?"

If it doesn't, you have data: this manager and possibly this company is not invested in your PM growth. Plan accordingly.

Script 2: "I need to be re-leveled"

Context: Your scope is at L5/PM level but your title and comp say L3/Senior Analyst. You want a leveling change.

This is a harder conversation than the title change. Companies resist re-leveling because each level has comp implications. Frame carefully.

Opening:

"I want to talk about my level and band. I think there's a mismatch between what I'm doing and where I'm leveled, and I'd like to make the case for a re-level.

Here's how I see it: my current band is [X]. The expectations for that band are [paraphrase from your company's leveling docs]. The work I've been doing — [specific examples] — matches the expectations for [next band], not my current band.

Specifically, [next band] expects [scope/responsibility]. I've been doing that for [time period]. [Examples].

I'd like to understand what the path to a re-level looks like, and if there's a gap, what specifically I need to demonstrate."

Manager response paths:

Path A: "I agree, let me put this through calibration." Calibration is the multi-manager review process where re-leveling decisions are made. This may take 1-2 cycles. Follow up with: "What's the timeline? What documentation can I prepare?"

Path B: "I see the work but the system doesn't allow re-leveling at this point." This may be true (some companies only re-level annually) or may be excuse. Probe: "What's the standard process? Can we put this on the agenda for the next cycle?"

Path C: "I'm not sure your impact justifies a re-level yet." Get specifics. "What impact would justify it? Help me understand the bar." Then decide: invest 6-12 months to close the gap, or recognize this is a stay-or-go signal.

Path D: "Re-leveling here doesn't really happen mid-cycle." Then ask: "When does the company review levels? How can I prepare for that conversation?"

The re-level conversation often takes 2-3 attempts across a year. Don't expect resolution in one meeting.

Script 3: "I have an offer; let me know if you want to retain me"

Context: You have a competing offer. You'd consider staying for the right counter.

This is sensitive. Done well: respectful, honest, productive. Done badly: damages trust permanently.

When to use this: only when you're genuinely willing to leave if they don't counter. Bluffing destroys credibility.

Opening (in person, with manager, in a planned 1:1):

"I want to share something with you in confidence. I've been having conversations with another company over the past few weeks, and I have an offer in hand. I'm telling you because I want to give you the chance to weigh in, not because I've made up my mind.

Here's the offer: [title], [company], [comp range — be specific]. The role is [scope]. The reason I was open to it: [genuine reason — usually scope, comp, or growth].

I value my time here, and I want to be honest: there's a version of this where I stay. That version probably looks like [specific change — title, comp, scope, manager — be honest about what would matter].

What I'm asking is: is there room to discuss what would make staying the better choice? I have [time window — usually 1-2 weeks] before I need to respond to the offer."

Manager response paths:

Path A: "Let me work on a counter." Don't celebrate yet. Wait for the actual counter. Counters can be aggressive (matches and adds), modest, or symbolic. Evaluate honestly.

Path B: "I appreciate you telling me. Let me think about it and come back tomorrow." Standard. Follow up: "Thank you. I want to be respectful of the timeline I've committed to with the other side. Can we talk by [day]?"

Path C: "I can't match that. I think you should take the offer." Honest. Sometimes the right answer for both sides. Take it gracefully.

Path D: "Let's see if we can match it but I need a few weeks to put it through." Push back politely. "I understand it takes time, but I have a deadline with the other offer. Can we get to a directional answer — even tentative — within 5 working days?"

What NOT to do

- Don't shop counters as leverage when you wouldn't actually leave. Caught once, your manager will never trust you again.
- Don't make this conversation public. One person, in confidence, in private.
- Don't enumerate grievances. This is a forward-looking conversation, not a complaint.
- Don't take a counter if your reasons for considering the move were structural (bad culture, no growth path, broken team). Counters fix comp, not culture. You'll be looking again in 6 months.

Script 4: "I disagree with this senior decision"

Context: Leadership has made a decision you think is wrong. You want to push back without damaging your career.

Setup: Schedule a 1:1 with the decision-maker, or with your manager who can carry the message. Frame as "I want to share my perspective on the recent decision."

Opening:

"I want to share my perspective on the [decision]. I want to be clear upfront: I'll commit to executing whatever the team decides. I'm not asking you to reverse anything. But I think my perspective adds something useful, and I want to share it before we move into execution.

Here's how I see it: [your view, in 3-5 sentences]. The reason I see it this way: [your evidence/reasoning].

The risk I'm worried about: [specific risk]. The signal that would tell us if my concern was right: [leading indicator].

I'd like to know: have these considerations been weighed? Is there context I'm missing that would change my view?"

The structure does three things:

1. Pre-empts defensiveness by stating you'll commit regardless.
2. Brings substance, not just opinion.
3. Treats it as a request for context, not a demand for reversal.

Decision-maker response paths:

Path A: "Yes, we considered that. Here's why we still went this way." Listen.

Sometimes you'll learn something. Sometimes you'll still disagree but understand. Either way, you're now informed and the decision-maker knows you're a thoughtful colleague.

Path B: "Actually, that's a good point. Let me think about it." Sometimes you change a decision. More often, you make the existing decision better.

Path C: "We considered it but decided differently. We need you to execute."

"Understood. I'll execute. I want to flag two things to watch for, and if they materialize, I'll come back to you." Then list the leading indicators of your concern.

This last path is the disagree-and-commit pattern done well: you've registered your dissent, the leader has heard it, the team executes, and there's a tripwire if you're proven right.

Script 5: "I'm leaving"

Context: You've decided to leave. You're delivering the news to your manager.

Setup: In person if possible. Don't do this over Slack. Schedule a 30-minute slot.

Opening:

"I want to share something difficult with you. I've decided to leave [company]. I've accepted a role at [company], and my last day will be [date — typically 4 weeks out].

The decision wasn't easy. I want you to know that [genuine appreciation for something specific — what you learned, the team, the work].

The reason I'm leaving: [honest reason — growth, comp, role, scope, life. Be honest but not bitter].

I want to make this transition as smooth as possible. Here's what I'm thinking: in the next 4 weeks, I'd like to [transition plan — wrap up specific projects, document handoffs, train successor if possible]. What would be most useful for you?"

What to do:

- **Be honest about why you're leaving** without bitter detail. "I want a different scope" is better than "I'm tired of this team's politics."
- **Don't badmouth.** Even if there are real reasons. The world is small.
- **Offer a real transition plan.** It signals you care about the team after you leave.
- **Don't accept counter-offers if you wouldn't have considered staying before.** Counter-offers fix comp, not the structural reasons you're leaving.
- **Don't stay longer than 4 weeks.** Productivity drops; awkwardness grows. 4 weeks is the standard professional notice.

Script 6: "I want to negotiate this offer"

Context: You've received an offer. You want to negotiate up.

Setup: Recruiter will be your counterpart. Email or call works. Phone is better for harder negotiations.

Opening (email version):

Subject: Offer follow-up

Hi [recruiter],

Thank you for the offer. I'm genuinely excited about [Company] and the opportunity to work on [specific thing].

Before signing, I wanted to discuss the comp package. Based on my background in [X], current market rates from sources like [Levels.fyi / competing offers], and the scope of this role, I was hoping to see:

- Base: \$[X] (vs offered \$[Y])
- Equity: \$[A] (vs \$[B])
- Sign-on: \$[Q]

I'm flexible on the mix; the total is what matters most. Is there room to revisit?

Happy to discuss on a call. Thanks for your support throughout the process.

Best, [your name]

Recruiter response paths:

Path A: "Let me see what I can do." Standard. Wait for response. Don't follow up for 3-5 days.

Path B: "I think we can stretch on sign-on but base is fixed." Negotiate the components: "I appreciate that. If base is fixed, can we discuss equity? My target is \$[A] total compensation; we're \$[gap] apart."

Path C: "We're at our limit on this offer." Acceptable response. Then probe: "I understand. Are there other components we could discuss — sign-on, vacation, start date, level?"

Path D: "Why are you asking for more?" Sometimes recruiters push back to test. Calmly explain: "Based on my research and what I'm hearing for similar roles, the comp range I see is [X-Y]. The current offer is below the range I'd expect for this scope."

What to know going in:

- **Most companies expect negotiation.** A 10-20% gap is standard.
- **All comp components are negotiable.** Base, equity, sign-on, level, vacation, start date.
- **Sign-on is often the most flexible.** Smallest perpetual cost to the company.
- **Equity can be substantial but uncertain.** Understand vesting, refresher policies.
- **Don't lie about competing offers.** Easy to verify; destroys trust.
- **Be willing to walk.** Best leverage is being able to say no.

Script 7: Asking for a stretch project

Context: You want to grow your scope. You need an opportunity.

Opening (with your manager, in a 1:1):

"I want to talk about my growth. I feel ready to take on more scope, and I'd like to discuss what that could look like.

Specifically, I'm interested in [specific area or project]. The reason: [why it matters strategically; why you're well-positioned].

I'm not asking for a title change today. I'm asking for an opportunity to stretch into work that goes beyond my current scope. If I do well, that becomes the case for the next conversation.

What's possible?"

This frames the conversation as "give me a chance to prove it" rather than "give me what I want." Lower resistance, higher success rate.

Script 8: Saying no to a request from above

Context: A senior leader (your VP, an exec) asks you to do something you think is wrong.

Opening:

"I want to be honest with you about [request]. I'm hesitant, and I want to share why before I commit.

Specifically: [reason]. The risk I see is [specific risk]. The cost would be [cost].

If you still want me to proceed after hearing this, I will. But I want to make sure my concerns are heard first."

This works because:

- It doesn't refuse outright.
- It surfaces substance, not just resistance.
- It defers to the senior person's authority while making them informed.
- It protects you politically if the concern proves correct.

If the senior leader proceeds anyway, execute and document. If your concern materializes, the documentation matters.

10.6 Managing up — to your manager and leadership

Your manager and senior leadership have limited time and asymmetric information. Skill at managing up massively amplifies your impact.

Principles

1. **Make their job easier.** Anticipate their questions. Frame issues with options. Don't dump problems on them.
2. **Be transparent about risks.** Surface bad news fast. The earlier they know, the more they can help.
3. **Match their style.** Some managers want detailed memos; others bullet points. Some voice; others async. Adapt.
4. **Reduce surprises.** They should never learn major news in a meeting they couldn't prepare for. Pre-brief.
5. **Make the ask explicit.** "I need your decision on X by Friday" beats "I want to discuss X."
6. **Track agreements.** Send notes after meetings: "Confirmed we'll do X by Y; you'll handle Z."

The weekly update — a power tool

A great weekly update to your manager (5-10 min read):

THIS WEEK

- What I shipped / made progress on
- Top 1-2 risks I'm tracking
- Key metric updates (with brief interpretation)
- Decisions I made (FYI)

NEXT WEEK

- Top 3 things I'll work on
- Anything I need from you

LONGER-TERM

- Anything I'm seeing that affects strategy
- Anything they should know about the team or org

ASKS

- Specific decisions I need from them
- Specific intros / unblocks

Send Friday evening or Monday morning. After 6 months of consistent weekly updates, your manager will trust you more than colleagues who deliver bigger projects but less reliably.

Working with difficult managers

- **The micro-manager:** Over-communicate proactively. They micromanage when uncertain; reduce their uncertainty.

- **The absent manager:** Become a self-driver. Build relationships across leadership for sponsorship.
- **The chaotic manager:** Take on the job of bringing order. Document agreements; create artifacts.
- **The political manager:** Be strategic about what you share and when. Document. Build broader relationships.

If a manager dynamic is genuinely toxic — disrespectful, retaliatory, ethically compromised — that's a different problem requiring HR or job change.

10.7 Managing down — to your team

PMs don't manage down (most engineers, designers don't report to PMs). But you do *lead*. Same principles, no formal authority.

Principles

1. **Make people feel valued.** Praise specifically and publicly; criticize specifically and privately.
2. **Share context generously.** People do better work when they understand why.
3. **Defend their time and quality.** Push back on stakeholders who ask too much.
4. **Take responsibility for failures.** Take public ownership of flaws; give the team the spotlight on wins.
5. **Help them grow.** Notice what each person wants in their career. Open opportunities.
6. **Be honest about scope and trade-offs.** Don't dress up bad news. Don't dress down good news.

What builds trust with engineering specifically

- **Pair on hard problems.**
- **Read their code (a little).**
- **Care about engineering quality.**
- **Don't bring half-baked specs.**
- **Defend deadlines** when sales pushes for unrealistic timelines.
- **Celebrate engineering work specifically.**
- **Be available for spec questions.**

What builds trust with design

- **Don't design in PRDs.** State problems and constraints; let designers explore.
- **Listen to design thinking.**
- **Defend design quality.**
- **Bring users to designers.**

- **Speak in user terms**, not aesthetic preferences.

10.8 Managing across — to peers

Peer relationships often determine whether you can ship things that depend on other teams. Investing here pays for years.

- **Build relationships before you need them.**
- **Reciprocate.** Help others; pay it forward.
- **Respect their domain.** Don't propose solutions in their area; share data and let them decide.
- **Make them look good.** Public praise to their leadership.
- **Never criticize peers in front of leadership.** Damages you more than them.

10.9 Executive communication — Pyramid Principle and BLUF

Executives are time-constrained pattern-matchers. Communicate with them differently.

The Pyramid Principle (Barbara Minto)

Lead with the conclusion. Then 3 supporting reasons. Then details.

Bad (chronological):

"We started by interviewing 30 users in November. We then ran a survey to 800. Based on those, we hypothesized activation was driven by feature X. We tested in A/B. Results were mixed. We refined the hypothesis. Eventually, we believe the answer is to pursue strategy A."

Good (pyramid):

"Recommendation: pursue Strategy A.

Why: Three reasons.

1. Our user research (30 interviews + 800 survey responses) shows activation is the dominant lever for retention.
2. Strategy A targets the activation mechanism most users described as broken.
3. Our A/B test of an intermediate hypothesis showed Strategy A's logic outperforms.

Detail follows below if useful."

The pyramid serves the executive: they get the answer in 30 seconds. If they want depth, it's there.

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

The first sentence states the conclusion. Subsequent sentences explain.

Bad email subject: "Q3 product update — please read" **Good email subject:** "Q3: We hit our retention OKR; activation slipped. Asking for \$X to address."

The reader knows what they're getting and whether to engage deeply.

Executive memo structure

TITLE: [Decision/topic in one sentence]

CONTEXT (2 sentences)

- What's the situation; why are we discussing this now?

RECOMMENDATION (1-2 sentences)

- What should we do?

KEY ARGUMENTS (3 bullet points)

- Each in 1-2 sentences with supporting evidence.

RISKS / TRADE-OFFS (3 bullet points)

- What could go wrong; what we're giving up.

ASK (1 sentence)

- What you need from the executive.

If you can't fit it in one page, you haven't synthesized enough. Length is a sign of insufficient thought.

Amazon's 6-page memo method

Amazon famously bans PowerPoint for important decisions. Instead: a 6-page narrative memo. The meeting starts with 30 minutes of silent reading, then discussion.

The discipline forces:

- Coherent narrative thinking (you can't hide behind bullet points).
- Explicit logic (no slides obscuring weak reasoning).
- Equal information for all participants.

For major strategic decisions, this format is genuinely better than slides.

The PR-FAQ method

Working backwards. Before building, write the press release announcing it. Then write the FAQ users would ask. This forces:

- Customer-language framing.

- Clarity on the value proposition.
- Identification of likely objections.
- Discipline to think from "future ready" backward to "what to build now."

If the press release sounds boring, the product probably is. If you can't write a credible press release, you don't know what you're building yet.

10.10 Visibility without being political

A real tension. PMs need to be visible to be promoted. PMs who optimize purely for visibility become loathed.

The line:

- **Visibility through substance.** Your work product is high-quality and shared. Your contributions to meetings are sharp. Your written artifacts are circulated. People know you because your work is good.
- **Visibility through politics.** You position yourself in meetings. You take credit for team work. You network for the sake of networking. People know you because you've made them know you.

The first is durable; the second backfires within 12-24 months.

Practices for substantive visibility

- **Write things that travel.** Blog posts, internal memos, launch announcements. Written artifacts compound your visibility.
- **Speak in meetings, but only when adding signal.** Quality > quantity.
- **Take public ownership of failures and private credit for wins.** Counter-intuitive but builds reputation faster.
- **Help peers visibly.** Not by self-promoting your help — by being known as someone who helps.
- **Invest in skip-level relationships.** Quarterly coffee with your skip-level. They learn who you are; you learn the bigger picture.

Anti-patterns to avoid

- **CC-ing executives on routine work.** Annoying. Counterproductive.
- **Volunteering for visible-but-low-value work.** You'll be seen, but seen as scrambling.
- **Self-promoting in performance reviews.** Comes off as insecure.
- **Networking purely for network's sake.** People sense it.

The PM who is visible because their work is good has a multi-decade career. The PM who is visible because they politicked has a 2-3 year career at each company before moving on.

10.11 Influencing senior leaders

Different from peers. Senior leaders are time-constrained and thinking at a higher level.

Adapt:

1. **Always have a recommendation.** Senior leaders don't want options dumped on them. They want a clear "I recommend X because Y." They might disagree, but they appreciate the commitment.
2. **Match their altitude.** A VP doesn't want to debate UI copy. They want to know if the strategic bet is right.
3. **Be respectful of their time.** A 10-minute conversation that respects time is worth more than a 30-minute one that wastes it.
4. **Tell them what they don't want to hear.** Senior leaders are surrounded by people telling them they're right. The PM who tells them honestly when they're wrong becomes valued (assuming they do it tactfully and with substance).
5. **Use written artifacts.** Senior leaders read between meetings. A great memo is more memorable than a great verbal pitch.
6. **Don't escalate as the first move.** Try to resolve at your level. Escalating signals you can't handle issues independently.

10.12 The PM career capital trap

A pattern senior PMs see repeatedly: high-performing PMs sometimes get stuck at mid-levels. Why?

The trap: doing your current job exceptionally well is the wrong investment for promotion past mid-levels. To get promoted, you need to demonstrate the *next level's* skills. But your current scope doesn't naturally let you demonstrate them.

The escape: take on stretch work that's bigger than your current scope. Volunteer for cross-team initiatives. Drive things outside your job description. Build relationships at the next level.

This is risky — stretch work can fail. But the safe path of doing your current job well leads to plateau.

The discipline: every 6 months, ask yourself: am I doing work that's stretching me, or am I just being excellent at what's familiar?

10.13 Practice exercises for Part 10

Exercise 10.1 — Stakeholder map

For your current project, map 10+ stakeholders on the power × interest matrix. For each, note: their goals, their fears, what currency speaks to them, your communication cadence.

Exercise 10.2 — Difficult conversation rehearsal

Pick three of the eight scripts in 10.5. For each, practice with a friend or AI. After, identify what felt awkward and rewrite.

Exercise 10.3 — Weekly update template

Set up your weekly update template. Send it to your manager for the next 4 weeks. Note their response. Adjust based on what they engage with.

Exercise 10.4 — Visibility audit

Honestly assess: am I visible through substance or through politics? What evidence supports each? What changes would shift toward more substance?

Exercise 10.5 — Manage up plan

For your manager specifically: what's their style? What do they care about? Where are you under-communicating? Write a 30-day plan to manage up better.

Exercise 10.6 — Career conversation prep

If you were having a re-leveling or title-change conversation in 30 days, what would you bring? Build the case: scope you've owned, outcomes you've driven, narratives that demonstrate the next level. Even if you're not having the conversation today, the artifact is valuable.

10.14 If you remember only one thing from Part 10

Influence is built one interaction at a time over years. The PMs who think about it tactically (this meeting, this email) plateau. The PMs who think about it as relationship investment compound. Your influence at year 5 is determined by the relationships you started building at year 1. Start now.

End of Part 10, v2.

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